

Foundations for Mindfulness (Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta) - read by Finola O'Siochru

Noirin Sheahan · Noirin's Teachings · 50:26

Tonight I want to talk about the four foundations for mindfulness. In Pali this is the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*. *Sutta* means a teaching or a discourse and the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta is considered the jewel of all the Buddha's teachings.

For the past few days we've been focusing on the Four Noble Truths. These describe the insights the Buddha discovered on his way to enlightenment. The Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta tells us how to observe our experience in order to come to these very insights. It's the how-to of the Dhamma.

It's often called the direct approach, by comparison to the indirect approach of *samatha* meditation, which includes an extra step, generating a deep state of concentration and peacefulness. The meditation described in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta is termed *vipassanā*, while the deeply peaceful states are termed *samatha jhāna*. In this teaching, the Buddha clarifies that we do not need to attain the samatha jhāna in order to have the insights necessary for liberation.

This is really good news for lay people because the samatha jhāna are best supported in secluded monastic conditions. By comparison, vipassanā is possible even when we are living a busy life. Perhaps to emphasize this, the Buddha addressed the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, the jewel of his teachings, to lay people. It was given when he visited the town of Kammāsadamma and was impressed by how diligently the native Kuru people were practicing mindfulness in their ordinary daily lives. Although the Buddha refers to the meditator as a *bhikkhu*, which nowadays only refers to an ordained monk, it originally referred to anyone who practiced the Dhamma.

Let's look for a moment at the word *satipaṭṭhāna*. The Pali word *sati* means mindfulness. The word *paṭṭhāna* is usually translated as foundation, but I like an alternative that Joseph Goldstein suggests: pasture. It evokes a pleasant image of the mind grazing in various pastures. This suggests restfulness, but also engagement. The mind isn't idly sunbathing in the pastures. It is finding and taking nourishment in each. Our journey to enlightenment involves nibbling and digesting the insights on offer when attention dwells in these pastures.

Think of a rural landscape with gently undulating ground. Our mind can rove around here and there, exploring all its little nooks and crannies, its bright patches and its shady copses. There are mucky patches too, and marshes and rocky cliffs and perhaps thickets of briars. Our job is to get to know them all.

Here and there in tonight's talk, I'm going to dovetail this teaching with that on the seven factors of enlightenment and with the wheel of dependent origination. So just a quick recap. The wheel describes the twelve-step process leading from ignorance to *dukkha*. The gardening image is a helpful way to remember the wheel, all the problems starting with the whirlwind of ignorance, carrying in seeds of *saṅk hāra*, which can then implant themselves and grow up to become a bed of weeds, which are themselves decaying and dying when we come to our final step of *dukkha*.

The seven factors are the beautiful qualities we develop in meditation. Remember our wild geese? These give an image for the seven factors. Mindfulness is in the lead supported by two flanks. There is a wide flank eager to push ahead and a slipstream flank calming everything down. If you want to put all three images together, think of our job in meditation being to get those wild geese into our pastures to nibble away at the seedlings before they grow into a thicket of briars and thistles.

Before describing each of the pastures, the Buddha describes the attitude needed for *vipassanā*. First, we need to be ardent. This indicates a degree of fervour. We speak of an ardent lover. We won't gain insight if we are cynical or offhand in our approach. We need to put our hearts into the practice.

The next phrase can be translated as mindful with clear comprehension. This corresponds with the factor of investigation in our seven factors. The phrase "ardent, mindful with clear comprehension" signifies mindfulness supported by the wide energetic flank of our wild geese.

The final phrase is: "Having put aside covetousness and grief with regard to the world." Thus we need to let our worldly cares take a back seat for the purpose of practicing *vipassanā*. This doesn't mean we suppress our cares. It means we let them become our focus for meditation whenever they show up. When grief shows up, we know we are grieving. Letting our worldly cares be examined like this helps focus the mind and cultivates calm and equanimity. So here we have the other flank of our wild geese, the slipstream.

The four pastures are body, feeling, mind and dhamma. It's interesting that the Buddha doesn't list these as four nouns as I've just done. Lists of nouns tend to objectify and simplify the world. The way the Buddha puts it tends to draw the world into our inner experience. He describes them within the meditation practice itself. "A bhikkhu abides contemplating the body as a body, ardent, fully aware and mindful, having put aside covetousness and grief with regard to the world. He abides contemplating feelings as feelings," and so on for all four.

Burying the noun within his description of the attitude needed for *vipassanā* suggests that the type of attention we bring into the posture matters as much, if not more, than the posture itself. The phrases "contemplating the body as a body, feelings as feelings," etc. are also striking. This indicates our attention needs to sink into these four areas to glean the wisdom offered by their contemplation. It is only by experiencing them mindfully with clear comprehension that they can deliver us from suffering.

The sutta then goes on to describe how to practice within each of the pastures. The section on body contemplation starts with the breath, knowing when we are breathing in and when we're breathing out, knowing when our breath is shallow and when it's deep. The next steps describe calming ourselves using the breath by bringing the thought of tranquility to mind as we feel the breath rise and fall. Remember, we talked of the need to calm ourselves whenever the wide flank of our wild geese are rushing ahead and tending to scatter the flock. So here is the Buddha's suggestion for doing just that: noting, calming, calming with each breath.

The next section is described as a refrain because it was repeated again and again throughout the sutta. It describes the various ways insight can arise. By insight, we mean a glimpse of some aspect of the Buddha's teaching, for example, the Four Noble Truths.

It may be an insight into the first truth, dukkha. We may really feel the changing nature of experience, that all experience is passing away like grains of sand slipping through our fingers, and sense that nothing lasts long enough to satisfy our deep needs for security.

Or we may get a glimpse of the second truth, that desire is the cause of dukkha. Suppose a memory of some argument has come up and we are embroiled in indignation and anger, insisting over and over again that we were right and the others were wrong. Every few moments we wake up to what's happening and feel the pain of this experience. Eventually, worn out and in despair, we give up the battle. Lo and behold, the pain disappears. We realise that clinging to the notion, "I was right," was what was causing us to suffer. It wasn't the memory, it was our reaction to it. That's a direct experience of the second noble truth.

A revolutionary thought surfaces. Maybe it doesn't matter much which of us was right or wrong. That moment when the pain disappeared was also an insight into the third noble truth, the fact that dukkha stops. We need to sensitise ourselves to those lulls in our emotional storms, to start taking them seriously. Until we're fully enlightened, dukkha will eventually start up again, perhaps as we start craving that this moment of peacefulness will go on forever. Sad, isn't it? We have to let peacefulness come and go, just as it will. Paradoxically, when we can surrender to that sad fact, we experience deeper peace.

At another time, we may get a glimpse of some aspect of the fourth noble truth. For example, we may be worrying that we're not meditating correctly, feeling nervous and constricted, as if we're going to get thrown out of the dhamma hall any moment. Then, miraculously it might seem, something changes and we decide, "I'm doing okay, this is good enough." Our hearts lighten, we stop worrying. Our attention sinks more easily into our breath and we sense the joy of simply being present, breathing.

In that moment we gain confidence that meditation could show us a way towards the end of suffering and we can see the importance of right attitude. When we were worrying and condemning ourselves, we were caught up in the hindrance of aversion. When we said, "This will do," we were accepting our experience. That's the only thing that changed. This gives us a direct insight into the fact that an accepting attitude is

integral to the path.

These are some examples of insights that can happen as we meditate. These insights can happen while we are following any of the exercises described in the sutta. The refrain tells us what to do in order to deepen our insight. There are three subdivisions to the refrain.

Firstly, the Buddha says, "In this way he abides, contemplating the body as a body internally." Contemplation requires full awareness and understanding. We're not just vaguely aware of breathing. The Mahāsi noting of the in-breath and out-breath gathers our mind in this way, calming us down and focusing our attention on the experience of breathing. This first section of the refrain reassures us that gathering the mind and calming ourselves is an integral part of gaining insight. We don't have to be calm and focused for insight. They can be sinking in as we are using the breath to encourage ourselves to calm down.

He then says we can practice in this same way, but externally. The most common interpretation for this is that we contemplate the breathing of another person. It would take very deep concentration to be able to discern when another person is breathing in or out, a much more challenging practice, which may be why it's so rarely taught. The next suggestion is even more challenging, to contemplate the body both internally and externally, following our own breath and that of another simultaneously—maybe in our next lifetimes.

Although I won't labour the point, it's worth knowing that he repeats this suggestion for all other exercises in the sutta, so we can gain insight by bringing awareness to the feelings of others, as well as to their mind states, for example. Although it would take supernormal powers to be able to directly intuit the feelings and minds of another person, it fosters *mettā* to make any attempt in that direction.

For the purposes of this retreat, we'll confine ourselves to our internal pastures. But outside of retreat, we can practice becoming more aware of others in this moment-to-moment fashion. Following their breathing, if we can detect it, their walking, their postures, daily activities and all the other exercises in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta that we'll go through now. This is a deep form of *mettā* practice. We have the Buddha's assurance that this is also a perfectly valid form of insight meditation.

So that's the first of the three suggestions in the refrain: to bring our full awareness and understanding to the breathing process. The second suggestion directs our attention to the transitory nature of bodily experience. Each breath arises and passes away and within that each sensation of breathing arises and passes away. He describes this as the arising and vanishing nature of the body.

He first directs our attention to its arising nature. Can you sense the breath coming into being each moment? The in-breath is particularly useful here. Can you feel its first manifestation and how it then continues to swell the body?

Next he directs attention to what he terms "the body in its nature of vanishing." One breath vanishes

before the next one can appear. The out-breath is most helpful here, following its movement moment after moment until it stops. His next suggestion is to be aware of both the arising and passing nature of the body. Here we sense the full breath, in and out, as a flow of discrete sensations. As one vanishes, the next arises.

These three exercises help us to see the truth of *anicca*, transience. Although our minds project continuity and permanence into the world, the experiential truth is that things are constantly changing. They arise and a moment later they vanish. We can nudge our minds towards this truth by experiencing the breath arising and passing as the Buddha suggests in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta.

His final suggestion for insight is simply to be aware of our bodies. In the Buddha's words, "Mindfulness that there is a body is simply established in him to the extent necessary for bare knowledge and mindfulness." This suggests a very light touch, bare knowledge. It's quite a contrast to the first suggestion, to abide contemplating the body as a body, which suggests more energetic gathering of our powers of attention and understanding.

So, we have the three suggestions for gaining insight. The first involves calming and focusing the mind on the body. The second explores its transitory nature. The third simply requires bare knowledge of the body.

The first describes the active effort we need to make to calm ourselves and steady attention within the felt sense of breathing. Here we're working on the slipstream flank of our wild geese. Once we're settled, we can afford to open our minds to be more exploratory. So this is where his second suggestion comes in. We explore the transitory nature of experience. This is the particular expertise of our wide flank, the ones that push us ahead.

At times our minds come to a point of delicate balance and we sense mindful investigation carrying on of its own accord. We sense any attempt we make to either calm or probe more deeply as slightly disturbing. So we can refrain from any effort. At this stage, the third suggestion, bare attention, comes into play.

At times this exploration pulls us towards a deep state of peace. Sometimes it's the opposite. We get fearful and all kinds of underlying emotions come to the surface. In both cases the third suggestion of bare knowledge can be applied. Take the emotional storm. This can batter us with wild thoughts and painful feelings. But so long as we're aware of a body that exists in the midst of it all, we're still on the direct path to enlightenment. We're in the pasture and our intelligence is open to insight even in the midst of a hurricane of anger or lust. We're not doing any deep investigation. It's just the lightest touch of body awareness. The geese are flapping around at a great rate, devouring the weeds.

Bare knowledge of the body also grounds us when the mind is being drawn towards the calm of a *jhāna*. In these states, we can lose touch altogether with our bodily sensations. The danger is that we also lose any degree of intelligence. If we have to keep remembering our physical nature, we would be bringing wisdom into the realm of *jhāna*. Our slipstream geese are lulling us to sleep, but the wide flank have just

enough energy to keep prodding us awake.

So no matter what aspect of the four pastures you are examining, you always have three choices for how to attend. You can calm and gather your attention by focusing on any of the exercises suggested in the sutta. When your attention is steady, you can examine the transitory nature of your experience. The final option, bare attention, applies when there is that knife edge of balance between calm and curiosity. It grounds you through temptations to drift into an emotion or jhāna state.

The Buddha's final comment in the refrain is that he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world. This is a reminder not to identify with whatever it is we are experiencing. Remember it's all going to change. If we cling to joy, calm or clarity, we will later be screaming with frustration when these are so unfairly taken from us. If we resist states like confusion and agitation, we unwittingly prolong them. In contrast, relaxing into them shows us that they also are composed of sensations and feelings which simply arise and pass away, nothing to be worried about, just another hillock in our pasture. All states can deliver the insight we need for liberation.

So that's the refrain. The various suggestions for how we look at our experience. The sutta then goes back to describing what it is we look at. First, we had the breath. The Buddha next goes on to describe four bodily postures as foundations for mindfulness: standing, sitting, walking or lying down.

The next section describes more broad-based mindfulness. Being fully aware when we are looking about, moving around, eating, drinking, talking, keeping silent, even defecating and urinating are included. This covers all of our daily life. After both sections the refrain is repeated in full. We might have an insight as we're sitting on the loo.

The next section involves the use of thought or mental images. We bring to mind the various parts of the body: hair on the head, body hair, nails, teeth, skin and all the way through the major organs and down to spittle, snot, oil of the joints and urine.

We don't often dwell on the separate parts of the body. The exercise can stir disgust or fear. But of course these can be experienced mindfully as a means of purifying our relationship with our bodies. We lose some level of deluded identification with our physical body as we go through this contemplation. Disgust changes to humble appreciation as we realise that our path to liberation depends on entities like snot, spittle, oil of the joints and urine as they do their quiet work to keep us alive.

The next section is more appealing, contemplating the body in terms of the four elements: earth, water, air and fire. While the previous exercise involves the faculty of thought and imagination, this exercise involves physical experience. The earth element describes the experiences of hardness, softness, weight and pressure. For example, try this exercise just now. Gently squeeze one hand within the other. Can you feel areas of bony hardness and fleshy softness? Squeeze more tightly. Can you feel the pressure? Try lifting one hand in the other. Can you feel its weight? All these are explorations of the earth element in

your body.

The water element is easier to experience externally as you're washing the dishes, for example, or taking a shower. Feel the way it flows around you, always changing its course to suit your shape. It can also be sensed as the fluidity in the movement of joints. Try rotating your wrist. Can you sense the fluidity required for this? Rotate your shoulders. It couldn't happen if the bones weren't separated by layer of fluid.

The air element is sensed in movement. Gently move your hands or arms now. How do you sense movement? Isn't it very subtle? As light as air. You can explore this during walking meditation, especially when the foot is moving forward.

The last of the elements is fire, which describes our sense of temperature. This includes both heat and coolness. Scan your body now to see if any areas feel warm. Try putting your hands on your face. Often there's a difference in temperature and so we feel both warmth and coolness. It can be hard to work out which part is cool and which is warm. Whenever you go outdoors, see can you sense any change in temperature. I find the exercise on the elements helps my attention to dwell on the body for longer periods.

By contrast, the next exercise is more likely to shoot my attention outwards into clouds of thought. This is the contemplation on death. In the Buddha's time, human bodies were left to decay in open areas called charnel grounds. He asked his followers to go there and watch the process of decay. Although this sounds horrific, the purpose is to meet our fear of death and come to terms with our mortality. We can practice this contemplation on death by reminding ourselves that our bodies too will fall ill, grow old and eventually die. If we can bear mindfully with any emotional responses, we may eventually come round to a deeper appreciation for the body in its present live and functional state, and a determination to make the best of this short stay on earth that we have been offered.

After each of these exercises, the Buddha repeats the refrain, emphasizing that insight can be gained as we do any of these. This brings to an end the section on the body. All of these exercises in this first foundation require that attention rest at the point of sense contact in the wheel of dependent origination, in this case involving sense contact from seeing, hearing, tasting, smelling and touching. Sense contact, the midpoint of the wheel, is where our inner world, our potential, finds an outlet to explore and perhaps express itself in the outer world. If we can ground ourselves at sense contact, the wheel can't turn all the way to *dukkha*. Our wild geese are pecking at the weeds the moment they show their head above ground.

The Buddha then goes on to describe the next foundation for mindfulness: feeling, which, as you may remember, is the next link in the wheel of dependent origination. Once our senses have made contact, we then categorise the sensation as pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. In Buddhism, that basic categorisation is what we mean by feeling. When the mind is tending to wander easily, it is often helpful to ask what feeling is fueling these thoughts. This can draw us towards the root of the problem, as it is our reaction to

feeling that drives the wheel to the wandering mind and thereby to *dukkha*.

Often there will be a zone of tension in the body corresponding to the attempt to cling to pleasure or get rid of unpleasant feelings. The emotion underlying the thoughts has its root here. If we can bring attention to that area of the body, we get a sense of ourselves clinging to some feeling at the centre of the knot. At that stage, our thoughts often quieten down.

However, this is not an easy process. Feeling is a more subtle level of experience than sense contact. We need a degree of calm and equanimity to be able to steady the mind on feelings. So have patience with this foundation. Coming back to our wild geese, when emotions run deep, the wide flank tends to go a bit wild when I turn attention on feelings. So it needs constant rebalancing. The body is a great help here. Coming back again and again to the sensations of breath or of posture takes the heat out of the situation. Slowly, slowly, catchy monkey.

After some perseverance, attention may be able to rest in or near the physical sensations associated with the emotion and be able to detect their pleasantness and the tendency to grasp onto this, or their unpleasantness and the tendency to push these away. The third category of feeling, neutral feeling, won't be at the core of emotional tension. We don't try to grasp or push away neutral feeling. The habitual reaction is to ignore it. We're working with neutral feelings when we're persuading our attention to rest on the breath and the footsteps. Our difficulty in holding attention steady is not that we dislike or are enthralled by the physical sensations, but that we want a more exciting focus.

Although it can be quite a challenge to get our attention to rest calmly in this foundation, the pickings are very rich. We're learning not to identify with our feelings, letting go of the habitual reactions of desire, aversion and ignoring. I'll say more about feelings tomorrow night, but for the moment I just want to mention that in this Sutta the Buddha also points out another distinction in feeling between worldly and unworldly feelings.

Worldly feelings are based on sense contact. Unworldly feelings are associated with spiritual endeavour. For example, generosity, *metta*, compassion, meditative joy are all unworldly feelings. They also happen to be pleasant feelings, and of course there's a danger that we cling to them unwittingly, thinking, "I am generous, I am filled with loving kindness," et cetera. This feels fine until something bursts that bubble. The fall to earth can be very sore and bring out the worst in us. Suddenly we hate everyone. But if we can be mindful of the pleasant feeling, we can appreciate it and use it to fuel our generosity and *metta* and all other beautiful states.

There can also be unpleasant feelings that come from spiritual endeavour. For example, we may feel ashamed or depressed because our minds keep wandering or because we can't understand the *Dhamma*. The big danger, of course, is to identify with these feelings and let ourselves become discouraged. But if we can open to the feelings, they can bring up a tender compassion for our unenlightened state. This is quite a deep degree of self-acknowledgement and self-care. Very healing. Once we sense this, the very

unpleasantness locks us into the compassionate response and thereby propels us along the path.

Neutral unworldly feelings are associated with equanimity. If we don't notice these, we can set up a subtle level of clinging, thinking, "I am equanimous." But of course, this bubble also bursts in time. If we acknowledge the neutral feelings, these can release us into a wise appreciation of equanimity.

The Buddha again repeats the refrain after describing this second foundation. Here he is clarifying that we can gain the insight needed for liberation by knowing whether we are feeling a pleasant, unpleasant or neutral feeling and knowing whether it comes from sense contact or spiritual endeavour. Similarly, we can study transience in our feelings, noticing that these too arise and pass away. As for the body, the third possibility is to simply note there are feelings, without any attempt to categorise or detect their transient nature.

The next section of the Sutta involves contemplating our mind. This involves, for example, knowing when we're angry or greedy, and all the variations on these. For example, anger may take on hues of irritation, fear, frustration, jealousy or cruelty. Greed can take the form of excitement, romance, lust, euphoria or passionate attachment. To correlate this with the wheel of dependent origination, we're now focusing on the early stages of the wheel, the stages prior to sense contact. These make up the attitude we bring into being at the point of contact.

We think we see and hear things objectively, but in fact our perception is coloured by whatever mind state is driving us to sense contact. I had a good illustration of this one time when doing walking meditation. It was a big airy room and I had been alone until someone came in and started walking quite close nearby. I felt myself contract in aversion. At the same time I could have sworn the room went dark. I had experienced the darkening of the room and the darkening of my mind simultaneously, and could intuitively sense their connection.

Nevertheless, I couldn't quite believe that my perceptions could be so easily modified. I looked out the window to check whether a big rain cloud had appeared, but it hadn't. The sky was still blue. Reluctantly I accepted that even my perception of light could be influenced by my mood. I was quite dismayed. The outside world wasn't quite so stable and objectively real as I had believed.

When we dwell mindfully in this foundation, we are noting what moods or mind states we're bringing to being at every point of sense contact. Otherwise, we're being controlled by the mind state. It is driving us into thought and action, but we're not conscious of this. We believe the thoughts. For example, something irritates us and we grow tense in indignation, generating thoughts like, "It's not fair." The resulting unpleasant feelings of tension prompt us to think yet again that it's not fair. So we think the thoughts again and again, convincing ourselves of their truth. The thoughts fuel the underlying emotion and so we get more deeply caught in the negative spiral.

The first step is to replace the thought stream with the noting word "thinking, thinking." This takes one

level of feedback out of the loop. The body is our great ally in coming close to the root of the problem. We might need to calm for a while, using the breath for example. Then, if we can feel where the body is tensing, this draws our attention towards the underlying emotion. We can simply note "feeling, feeling" here. But sometimes getting the right noting word is like hitting the nail on the head. All the mind state really wants is recognition. The more often we bring attention into this foundation, the better we get at discerning our moods and emotions. In this case, for example, noting "indignation" might bring a palpable release of that pent-up energy.

However, if the emotion runs deep, we must be patient and keep on noting while it eventually burns itself out. A moment's lapse in mindfulness and we will be building up the story of how unfair life is again.

The Buddha's advice is very simple. For example, he notes "a mind affected by anger as a mind affected by anger." There is no judgment required. Simple acknowledgement of our afflicted mind states is all that is required. Judgment tends to contract us further. But of course, we can't undo our habit of judging so easily. So whenever we sense that we're adding the second arrow of self-judgment, we simply let attention graze in the feel of judgment, feeling its physical expression in our bodies as well as whatever emotions show up: disapproval, self-disgust, self-hatred. From the point of view of insight, all these are equally welcome. Wisdom grows as we witness these.

The Sutta also advises us to note the absence of mind states like greed and anger. This isn't something we often do. We tend only to notice our minds when they're troubled, not when they're clear and at ease. But noticing the absence of trouble helps us appreciate those states. We find it easier to let go of excitement, for example, when we learn to appreciate the pleasantness of being calm.

Just now, for example, are you angry? If not, note "not angry, not angry," and get a felt sense of that mental state. Similarly, you could ask yourself if your mind is excited, wanting more stimulation. If not, note "not excited, not excited." We need to get to know these unobtrusive mind states. Our minds like familiarity. What the mind knows and is familiar with, it comes back to again and again.

Apart from the variations on greed and anger, our minds can be deluded, thinking there is a very powerful me in control of all my experience. Again, we can simply note this as "delusion, delusion." The belief and the felt experience may be the same, but they have now been brought within the foundation for wisdom to graze upon. Very gradually the wild geese nibble away at our delusions. Similarly, we can note the presence or absence of sleepiness, restlessness, distraction, concentration, peacefulness and any mind state.

The Buddha then repeats the refrain, reiterating that insight can be gained as we note the presence or absence of our mind states, as we sense them arise and pass away, or as we simply ground ourselves in the knowledge that there is a mind without any attempt to be more discerning than that. The latter is the kind of light touch mindfulness we need when any attempt to probe more deeply would disturb the experience.

The final foundation is called *Dhammas* and there's a lot of controversy about how to translate this. The *Dhamma* is the teaching of the Buddha and is usually spelled with a capital D. But the word *dhammas* here is plural and with a small d. The classical translation is "mind objects." But that's not very helpful since all the other foundations can also be described as mind objects. We make the body, feelings and mind into objects for contemplation in those foundations.

Recently the translation "categories of experience" is gaining favour. But that's not very elegant. It's hard to relate to. Looking ahead to see what the foundation describes, it is actually a number of the Buddha's teachings. The teachings he picks out include the hindrances, the factors of enlightenment and the four noble truths, as well as two more which we'll discuss over the next two evenings. In my simple way of thinking, I can see why we don't call this foundation the *Dhamma*, because here we are in fact contemplating the central core of the Buddha's teachings.

Whatever we call it, this last foundation asks us to let our attention dwell on the moment-to-moment experience of the hindrances, factors of enlightenment, four noble truths and other teachings. This makes it abundantly clear that these teachings are not simply lists of human attributes or philosophical statements. The *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta* clarifies that we must know and understand these teachings within the realm of our individual subjective experience. We are to let our attention dwell on these teachings as they manifest in our body and mind, ingesting their wisdom moment by moment until we eventually see these from the Buddha's point of view. This is what it means to be a follower of the Buddha.

I'm not going to say any more about this foundation tonight, because all the teachings mentioned here are explored in other talks. Let's just skip to the conclusion of the *Sutta*, where the Buddha assures us that if we can explore our experience, according to *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, for just seven days, we will have deep, deep insight, perhaps even full liberation. Luckily, there are still seven days left in this retreat. So now you know what you have to do.

Persuade yourself to be an ardent lover of truth. Bring your mindful intelligence to the quest for truth. Put aside your worldly cares, or if they refuse to subside, let them become the focus for meditation. Draw your mind into whichever foundation beckons you. When you're settled, start exploring the transient nature of your experience. Lighten the attention to bare registration of the foundation when you feel that would suit the situation best. That's all. As Bhante would say, "Easy-weezy-peasy."

May your exploration of the four foundations for mindfulness bring you to full enlightenment in this very lifetime.

Transcriptions produced locally using Swiss low-carbon electricity. Corrections and rewriting by cloud-hosted AI.